she have the promised boy? It was not to be; Bibi Gunwar had a girl.[21]

Humayun's dreams, like his reality, had disappointed him. What was the point, anyhow, of visions, no matter how propitious? Whether it was Kamran who schemed or Humayun who grovelled, there was little either man could do to stop Sher Shah – and when news arrived that the Afghan's army had crossed the Beas river east of Lahore, the Mughals did the only thing they could. They ran away.[22]

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In the way that it's usually told, as an interlude to better things, the story of Humayun is of a man undone by weakness, whimsy and sentimentality; a 'delicate king' (*padshahi latif*), as one of his own courtiers described him.[23] He was an emperor more interested in the movements of stars than in the affairs of men, and far too indulgent of his brothers – Kamran foremost – who did all they could to undermine Humayun's authority and usurp his empire.

It is possible, however, that Humayun was far less careless of his interests than he is reputed to have been. A soldier-historian called Nizamuddin Ahmad relates an odd bit of intrigue that casts a murky light on Humayun's seemingly effortless accession to his father's throne. The popular story is that Humayun fell ill and Babur offered God his own life in exchange for his son's. God accepted. Immediately, Humayun began to recover and Babur's health declined. With one last effort of will, the emperor pronounced his eldest son his heir, then took to his bed and died.

As Nizamuddin tells it, however, Babur's last days were spent against a backdrop of dizzy conspiracy. The story is this: a trusted, high-ranking chieftain in Babur's court, Mir Khalifa, conceived a mysterious antipathy towards the prince Humayun and proposed his own candidate for the throne: Mahdi Khwaja, a 'generous and liberal young man' who had the advantage of being married to Babur's beloved sister, Khanzada Begum. The idea gained traction, then quickly went to Mahdi Khwaja's head – so much so that he began plotting against his own advocate, Mir Khalifa, who promptly withdrew his support for the two-faced would-be heir, and had him arrested instead.[24]

Humayun, meanwhile, had long been aware of competing interests for